

Variations on assignments on MM and the blazon (used with “Those Various Scalpels” and “Roses Only”)

--Bonnie Costello

I use the following assignment in various ways, in a course I call “Portraits in Literature,” in an upper level survey in modern poetry, in a course called “Modern Poetry and the Visual Arts” and in a course on Moore, Bishop and Plath. I often use these materials in class, though some of the juxtapositions can also make nice writing assignments.

The core of this assignment is Moore’s “Those Various Scalpels” though “Roses Only” works well with it. How does Moore’s poem respond to the long tradition of the blazon? Start with Shakespeare’s sonnet 130 (My Mistress’ Eyes) and perhaps one of the Petrarchan poems that he is satirizing. Might Moore’s poem be understood as a new (feminist oriented?) entry in this old conversation? Or should we read the poem along with Herrick’s “Delight in Disorder,” as a study in aesthetic taste, using women’s dress as a metaphor for poetry? Williams’ “Portrait of a Lady” can add yet another element to this cluster on modern responses to a Renaissance

convention.

If the course is on modern poetry, Moore's "Those Various Scalpels" can be juxtaposed directly to Pound's "Portrait d'une Femme" since they even share some imagery, and Eliot's "Portrait of a Lady." How do the male poets' critiques differ from Moore's? Finally, if the course is on poetry and the visual arts, I recommend a comparison between Moore's poem and Hannah Hoch's DaDandy or Dada Dolls. How does the technique of collage work across media?